Lost at C

By Jean Shepherd

A wave of numbness surged through my body with stunning force. At last I knew what it felt like to be sitting with that brass hat on your skull . . . with those straps around your ankles . . . as the warden pulls the big switch. Out of the corner of my eye I caught the glint of Mr. Pittinger's horn-rims and the ice-blue ray from his left eye. As the giant equation loomed on the blackboard, my life unreeled before my eyes. I was finished. Done. It had all come to this. Somehow I had always known it would . . . I was . . .

INTRODUCTION

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It all started in first grade at the Warren G. Harding School where I was one among a rabble of sweaty, wrestling, peanut-butter-and-jelly-sandwich

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eaters. But it was not until the end of the third month of school that I became dimly aware of a curse that would follow me throughout my life. Along with Chester Wozcniewski, Helen Weathers and poor Francis Xavier Zambarbieri, I was a member of the alphabetical ghetto that sat in the back of the classroom. Medical science is now beginning to realize that those of us at the end of the alphabet live shorter lives, sweat more and are far jumpier than those in the Bs and Es and even the Ms and Ls. People at the tail end of the alphabet grow up accepting the fact that everybody else comes first.

Kids in the front of the classroom didn't know the meaning of danger. Ace test takers, they loved nothing more than to display their immense knowledge by waving their hands frantically even before questions were asked. They were the smartasses who went on to become corporation presidents, TV talk-show guests and owners of cabin cruisers.

We in the back of the classroom followed a different path. First of all, it was imperative never to be caught out in the open; if possible, not to be seen at

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all. Each one of us evolved his own methods of survival. Helen Weathers was so fat, her profuse perspiration under stress so pathetic that the teacher never had the heart to call on her. Woczniewski hid behind books, which worked all right until he hid behind Plastic Man Meets the Thing one morning. Zambarbieri, a devout Catholic, relied almost exclusively on prayer. I made it a point to wear bland-colored clothes, the better to blend into the background. I learned to weave my body from side to side, dropping a shoulder here, shifting my neck a few degrees to the right there, with the crucial object in mind of always keeping a line of kids between me and the teacher's eagle eye.

The [second] and possibly most important, tactic of classroom survival is thought control. When danger looms, it is necessary to repeat silently, with intense concentration, the hypnotic command "You will not call on me, you will not call on me," sending out invisible waves of powerful thought energy until the teacher's mind is mysteriously clouded.

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Woczniewski, Helen Weathers and I, as well as poor old Zambarbieri, sat on shore as the deepening river of education flowed by us unheard, unseen. Warren G. Harding was widely known, during the dark ages when I was attending it, for being an "advanced" school, and actual tests were very rare. This worked in beautifully with our survival techniques and made it possible for me and my band of fellow ignoramuses to slide by year after year undetected.

The years passed, punctuated by occasional tight squeaks, but my true identity as a faker was never really in danger of exposure. And finally the big day came. On a glorious sun-drenched morning, graduation day arrived. I had made it. I got my diploma. It was official. In September I would be a full-fledged high school kid.

[Summer flew by until FINALLY September arrived] I had lain in bed making plans the night before. I would grab the front seat in every class and listen to every word. No longer would I duck and dodge behind a screen of kids. That was all behind me. Mentally I crouched at the mark, waiting for the starter's gun to

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send me flying down the track ahead of the pack. The bus rolled up before nirvana and we piled out.

A blind torrent of fear washed over me. For a while, I had been one of the truly big men at Warren G. Harding, and now I was nothing. Clinging to my lunch bag with a sweaty hand, I hunted frantically for a familiar face, but . . . BRRRR-INNNGGG! Great staircases with rivers of kids streamed in all directions. My card read REPORT TO ROOM 220. Kids all around me hollered and laughed back and forth. They all seemed to know one another. I had never felt so alone. Figuring astutely that room 220 had to be on the second floor, I joined the torrent raging upward. I tried to read the numbers on doors as I was swept onward like a salmon in the spawning season: 205, 207, 214, 218 - 220! My home room.

A plump lady with gray clothes, hair and face sat like an enigmatic Buddha at a green metal desk at the head of the room. She glanced up and peered at me coldly through her rimless glasses. "Your card, please," she snapped in a flat voice. I handed it over. "Take that

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seat there back of Rukowski. He's the one in the purple sweater." I walked down between the aisles of alien faces to my seat. It was, of course, in the next-to-the-last row. It would be mine for the next four years.

"Freshmen, this "is your first day in high school. You are no longer in grade School. If you work hard, you will do well. If you don't, you 'will regret it. You are here to learn. You are not here to play. Remember this and remember it well: What you do here will follow you all through life." She paused dramatically. "Your first class will begin in five minutes. Any questions?" No one raised a hand. I sat there in silence, staring at my blue card, lost in dark thoughts, when the bell rang out again. The starting gate had opened. As the crowd surged around me, I struggled to read my program card. All I could make out was room 127. I had only a minute to make it, so I battled my way down a flight of stairs. Then: 101, 105, 109, 112, 117- 127, just in time.

A tall, square man stood motionless at the blackboard. He had a grim blue jaw and short, kinky, black crewcut hair. His eyes were tiny ball bearings

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behind glasses with thick black rims. He wore a dark, boxy, suit that looked like it was made of black sandpaper. The bell rang and the door closed behind us.

"All right. Settle down. Let's get organized." The man's voice had a cutting rasp to it, like a steel file working on concrete. "We sit alphabetically in this class. A's up here in front to my right. Get going." I trudged behind Helen Weathers toward the dim recesses in the back of the classroom. It was about a quarter of a mile to the front of the room, but I sat bolt upright in my seat, determined to catch every word the teacher said. "Class, my name is Mr. Pittinger." And I still had no idea what he taught. I would soon find out.

He turned, picked up a piece of chalk and began to scrawl huge block letters on the blackboard. A-L - the chalk squeaked decisively - G-E-B-R-A. Algebra? What the hell is that? "Algebra is the mathematics of abstract numbers." I gulped as I wrote this down.

"I will now illustrate." Pittinger printed a huge Y on the blackboard and below it an enormous X. "If Y equals five and X equals two, what does the following

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mean?" He wrote out: X + Y = ? Black fear seized my vitals. How could you add Xs and Ys? I had enough trouble with twos and threes. Already the crowd in front of the room were waving their hands to answer Pittinger's question. I sank lower in my seat, a faint buzzing in my ears. I knew it was all over. Helen Weathers had flung up a thin spray of sweat. And from behind me I could hear the faint, steady click of Zambarbieri's rosary. Second by second, minute by minute, eon by eon, that first algebra class droned on. I couldn't catch another word that was said, and by the time Mr. Pittinger wrote the second equation on the board, I was bobbing and weaving like a cobra and sending out high-voltage thought rays. A tiny molten knot of stark terror hissed and simmered in the pit of my stomach. I realized that for the first time in my school life, I had run into something that was completely unlearnable, and there was no way to fake it.

That night, sleep did not come easily. In fact, it was only the first of many storm-tossed nights to come as, algebra class by algebra class, my terror grew. All my

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other subjects - history, English, social studies - were a total breeze. My years of experience in fakery came into full flower. In social studies, for example, the more you hoked it up, the better the grades. On those rare occasions when asked a question, I would stand slowly, with an open yet troubled look playing over my thoughtful countenance. "Mr. Harris, sir," I would drawl hesitantly, as though attempting to unravel the perplexity of the ages, "I guess it depends on how you view it-objectively, which, naturally, is too simple, or subjectively, in which case many factors such as changing environment must be taken into consideration...." I would trail off. Mr. Harris, with a snort of pleasure, would bellow: "RIGHT! There are many diverse elements, which...," After which he was good for at least a 40 minute solo.

Every morning at 8:35, however, was another story. I marched with leaden feet and quaking bowels into Mr. Pittinger's torture chamber. By the sixth week I knew, without the shadow of a doubt, after all these years of dodging and grinning, that I was going to fail.

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Fail! There was no question whatsoever. True, Pittinger had not yet been able to catch me out in the open, since I was using every trick of the trade. But I knew that one day, inevitably, the icy hand of truth would rip off my shoddy facade and expose me for all the world to see.

I stumped into algebra class [day after day, month after month] feeling distinctly like the last soul aboard the Titanic as she was about to plunge to the bottom. [I remember it like it was yesterday . . . it was late May] The class began, Pittinger's chalk squeaked, hands waved. The sun filtered in through the Venetian blinds. A tennis ball pocked back and forth somewhere over a net. My knot of fear, by now an old friend, sputtered in my gut. True, I had avoided being called on even once the entire year, but it was a hollow victory and I knew it. Minute after minute inched slowly by as I ducked and dodged, Pittinger firing question after question at the class. Glancing at my Pluto watch, I noted with deep relief that less than two minutes remained before the bell. It was then that I made my

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fatal mistake, the mistake that all guerrilla fighters eventually make: I broke cover.

For years, every fiber of my being, every instant in every class, had been directed at survival. On this fateful Wednesday, lulled by the sun, by the gentle sound of the tennis ball, by the steady drone of Pittinger's voice, by the fact that there was just two minutes to go, my mind slowly drifted off into a haze of daydream.

(in an echoing intonation similar to teacher's voices in Charlie Brown) [WAA, WHAA WAA WAA] For a stunned split second, I thought I'd been jabbed with an electric cattle prod. Pittinger's voice, loud and commanding, was pronouncing my name. He was calling on me! Oh, my God! With [only] a minute to go, he had nailed me.

"Come to the board, please. If X equals two and Y equals minus one, what is the value of C in this equation?" snapped Pittinger. In a stupor of primal fear, I felt my legs clumping up the aisle. On all sides the blank faces stared. At the board - totally unfamiliar

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territory to me - I stared at what seemed like the first equation I had ever seen. It was well over a yard and a half long and was lacerated by mysterious crooked lines and fractions in parentheses, with miniature twos and threes hovering above the whole thing like tiny barnacles, and Xs and Ys were jumbled in crazy abandon. Pittinger stood to one side, arms folded. He had been playing with me all the time. He knew!

I glanced back at the class. It was one of the truly educational moments of my life. The entire mob was grinning happily, licking their chops with joyous expectation of my imminent crucifixion.

"The value of C, please," said Pittinger. Desperately, I tried to come up with a number - any number. I couldn't remember my name. "The answer, please."

"Three," I muttered.

"What's that?" barked Pittinger.

"Three!" I blurted.

Pittinger staggered backward, his glasses jolted down to the tip of his nose. "How the hell did you know

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that?" he bellowed hoarsely, his snap-on bow tie popping loose in the excitement. The class was in an uproar. It was a true miracle. I had walked on water. Instantly, the old instincts took over. In a cool, level voice, I answered Pittinger's rhetorical question.

"Sir, I used empirical means to arrive at the answer."

He paled visibly and clung to the chalk trough for support. On cue, the bell rang out. The class was over. With a swiftness born of long experience, I was out of the room even before the echo of the bell had ceased. A legend had been born.

The next morning, Thursday, I swaggered into algebra class with head high. Even Jack Morton, the biggest smartass in the class, said hello as I walked in. Mr. Pittinger, his eyes glowing with admiration, smiled warmly at me. "Hi, Pit," I said with a casual flip of the hand. We abstract mathematicians have an unspoken bond. Naturally, I was not called on during that period. After all, I had proved myself beyond any doubt. [X+Y = 3 . . . and I never used Algebra again]

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